become is not revealed now but it is predetermined. Forget this failure, as it was essential to lead you to your destined path. Search, instead, for the true purpose of your existence. Become one with yourself, my son! Surrender yourself to the wish of God," Swamiji said.

I returned to Delhi and enquired at the DTD&P(Air) about the outcome of my interview. In response, I was handed my appointment letter. I joined the next day as Senior Scientific Assistant on a basic salary of Rs 250/- per month. If this was to be my destiny, I thought, let it be so. Final y, I was fil ed with mental peace. No more did I feel any bitterness or resentment at my failure to enter the Air Force. Al this was in 1958.

At the Directorate, I was posted at the Technical Centre (Civil Aviation). If I was not flying aeroplanes, I was at least helping to make them airworthy. During my first year in the Directorate, I carried out a design assignment on supersonic target aircraft with the help of the officer-in-charge, R Varadharajan, and won a word of praise from the Director, Dr Neelakantan. To gain shop-floor exposure to aircraft maintenance, I was sent to the Aircraft and Armament Testing Unit (A&ATU) at Kanpur. At that time,